

The Pintail Experience

Game Plan for the December 30 Trip

May 2026

Pintail Experiences — Game Plan for the December 30 Trip

The trip is on the books. 16 spots filled. About 7 months out. This is the plan to make money on it, deliver an experience that gets talked about, and end the year with momentum.

What Matters

1. **Make money on this trip.** Pricing $\times$ 16 has to cover everything plus pay the founder real money. Don't comp seats. Don't underprice.
2. **Deliver an experience the 16 won't shut up about.** That's the entire marketing budget for trip #2.
3. **Capture content.** Photos and at least one short film. You'll use them forever.
4. **Get the next 1-2 trips on the books by word of mouth.** Ask every attendee on day 3, "Who do you know who would love this? Introduce us."

Everything else can wait.

What Doesn't Matter Right Now

- Corporate sales motion / C12 outreach
- Three product tiers (Corporate / Father-Son / Church)
- Multi-year roadmap
- LLC vs 501(c)(3) hybrid structure (basic LLC is fine for now — sort the rest later)
- Branding overhauls beyond what's needed for this trip
- Scale planning, hiring, recurring memberships

Park all of it.

One Parallel Track — The Software

The custom platform is being built alongside the trip prep, not before or after. It runs in parallel because (a) there are no software expectations from the 16 attendees, so anything shipped is a delight, (b) it's the cheapest, highest-leverage marketing engine for trip #2, and (c) it doesn't compete with trip prep — different work, different hours. See **Pintail Experience — Software Build Plan.md** for the full 7-phase build (target: live for the 16 by mid-November, polished by Dec 30).

Step 1 — Know if This Trip Actually Makes Money

Before anything else, build a one-page spreadsheet. Plug in real numbers:

Line	Per person	× 16
Trip price (what each attendee is paying)	?	?
Lodge cost (pass-through)	?	?
Food & beverage (if not in lodge fee)	?	?
Ground transport / shuttles	?	?
Branded gear / welcome kit	?	?
Photographer / videographer	? (spread)	?
License / stamps (or pass-through to attendees)	?	?
Insurance	?	?
Curriculum materials	?	?
Founder + father-in-law time	?	?
Contingency (10%)	?	?
Margin	?	?

If the margin doesn't pay him real money for ~3 weeks of full-time work (prep + execution + wrap-up), the trip isn't priced right. **Better to raise prices by \$500/seat now than to lose money proving the concept.** If anyone pushes back, that's information — it tells you the right ICP for trip #2.

Step 2 — Lock the Money In

- **Confirm deposits are collected** on all 16 seats. If anyone hasn't paid, get it done this week.
- **Set a final-payment deadline** at least 60 days before the trip (so late October). Stick to it.

- **No refunds inside 60 days** — make this clear in writing now if it isn't already. Trip-cancellation insurance can be recommended to attendees who want it.
 - **Set up payment collection** — Stripe link or WeTravel (2.9% fee, branded itinerary built in). Either works. WeTravel is built for this exact use case.
 - **Open a separate bank account** for Pintail. Don't run trip money through his personal account.
 - **QuickBooks Self-Employed** (~\$15/mo) or just a clean spreadsheet for now. Track every dollar in and out.
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Step 3 — Design the Experience Hour-by-Hour

The 16 are paying for a feeling, not a hunt. The hunt is the excuse. Map the trip as a 3-day (or whatever length) arc:

Arrival — The first 30 minutes set the tone. Branded welcome bag in the room (leather journal from Pintail Goods, schedule, a personal note from the founder, a flask or knife with their initials). Founder greets every guest by name. They should feel like they walked into something special, not a hotel check-in.

Daily rhythm — Morning hunt → big breakfast → midday rest / clays / fishing / fire pit → afternoon hunt or activity → cocktail hour → dinner → evening session. The evening session is where the curriculum lives — keep it tight (45-60 minutes), don't over-program, leave space for the men to keep talking after.

The curriculum touchpoints — Three is the right number: - **Day 1 evening:** Identity / calling — who God designed you to be - **Day 2 evening:** Leading at home — being the man your family needs - **Day 3 evening:** The blessing — sending them out (this is the one they remember)

Father-in-law teaches. Founder facilitates and connects. Don't make it feel like a sermon — make it feel like dinner with a guy who has spent 30 years thinking about this.

Small touches that punch above their weight — a moment of prayer with the dog handlers before the first hunt; cigars and bourbon around a fire on night 2; a single solo walk built into day 2 (15 minutes alone, a verse, a question to sit with); the founder personally cleaning a bird for each attendee.

Departure — Don't end with a thud. Final breakfast, the blessing, send them home with something physical (a print of the group photo from the hunt, a written copy of the curriculum, a leather Pintail patch). And the ask: "Who do you know who would love this?"

Step 4 — Lock the Logistics on a 7-Month Clock

Now → end of May (T-7 months) - Lodge contract signed in writing (deposit + cancellation terms) - Curriculum outline drafted with father-in-law (3 evening sessions, devotional bits for meals) - Confirm all 16 deposits collected - Welcome email to the 16 — sets the tone, opens the communication channel - Set up the Pintail bank account, payment system, and tracking spreadsheet

July (T-5 months) - Order branded gear and welcome kits — **leather has long lead times**, start now - Book photographer and (ideally) videographer for the full trip - Confirm dog handlers, ground transport, and any sub-vendors with the lodge - Finalize the menu with the lodge chef (any signature dishes, dietary notes)

September (T-3 months) - Father-in-law's teaching scripts finalized — dry-run with founder over a weekend - Send attendees the licensing/stamp instructions, gear suggestions, and packing list - Insurance and liability waivers ready to send - Build the contingency plan: weather, late drops, replacement attendees, the founder getting the flu — what happens? - Get final payments in

November (T-1 month) - Final headcount, dietary restrictions, room assignments, transport schedule - Run-of-show document — every hour of every day on one page - One full dry-run of the curriculum with father-in-law - Send attendees the final pre-trip note: travel logistics, what to bring, what to expect emotionally (set the bar high)

Dec 30 (T-0) - Arrive a full day early. Sleep there the night before. Walk the property. Check every welcome kit. Pray over the trip. Then run it.

Step 5 — Communicate With the 16 So They Show Up Hyped

Six touchpoints between now and the trip:

1. **Welcome email this week** — vision, what to expect, “you’re in”
2. **Monthly drip** (June–November) — a short teaching snippet from father-in-law, a destination teaser, a gear tip, occasional payment reminder. Keep it warm, not corporate.
3. **T-60 logistics email** (late October) — final payment due, travel info, packing list
4. **T-14 final note** (mid-December) — what to expect, contact info, anything they need to hand-carry
5. **Day-of welcome** — in person, by name
6. **Post-trip** — thank-you note within 48 hours, photos within a week, the referral ask within two weeks

Step 6 — Capture Content Like Your Next Trip Depends On It (Because It Does)

At minimum: one good photographer for the full trip. Better: one photographer + one videographer to produce a 2-3 minute brand film. That film is the single most leverage-able asset for selling trip #2.

What to capture: dawn duck blinds with fog, dogs working, the founder teaching by firelight, hands holding birds, a quiet moment of prayer, the group laughing at dinner, the father-in-law speaking, a son with a father. The faces matter more than the birds. Get talking-head testimonials on the last morning while everyone is still emotionally open.

Budget \$3K-\$8K for content. It's the highest-ROI line item on the whole P&L.

Step 7 — Trip #2 Plans Itself if Trip #1 Lands

After Dec 30, in January, do four things:

1. **Send each attendee the photos and the film.** They'll forward it to friends without being asked.
 2. **Ask the question:** "Who do you know who would love this?" One personal email to each of the 16. Expect 5-10 of them to introduce you to at least one friend. That's how trip #2 fills.
 3. **Lock the next 2-3 dates** at the same lodge or a sister lodge — different season, maybe duck instead of quail or vice versa. Get them on the founder's website by mid-January.
 4. **Decide whether to raise the price.** If trip #1 was oversubscribed and the experience landed, raise it 20-30% for trip #2. The Christmas/New Year's slot you have now is gold.
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Five Things That Could Sink This Trip

1. **Late cancellations.** Holidays are risky — people's plans shift. Lock the no-refund window in writing now and consider one alternate on a standby list.
2. **Lodge problems.** Get the contract in writing, confirm the lodge has a backup plan for severe weather or property issues, and stay in monthly contact with the lodge manager.
3. **Curriculum feels preachy.** The father-in-law's job is to teach like he's having a conversation, not preaching from a stage. Dry-run it. Cut anything that feels heavy-handed.

4. **The founder runs himself ragged.** He's doing three jobs (sales, ops, host). By trip #3 he needs help — but for this one trip, just be honest about what he can't do and outsource it (e.g., don't try to be the photographer too).
 5. **Underpricing.** If he netted \$20K on this trip when he could have netted \$40K, that's a year of his life he just lost. Charge what it's worth. People paying for a curated faith-based hunting retreat are not price-shopping.
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The One-Sentence Goal

Dec 30, the 16 men leave changed, the founder walks away with real money in the bank and a 2-minute film, and 5+ of the 16 introduce friends in January.

If that happens, this business works. Everything else gets figured out from there.